

Capture, Control, Create

If you have a TV-Tuner, you need PVR software. Here's a little comparison of some of the better ones out there

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More and more people are using their PCs as TVs, and software is being developed by the dozen to help you get the best from your TV-Tuner card. With Media Center PCs becoming more popular, TV-Tuner software are also being better designed; however, Personal Video Recorder (PVR) software hasn't entirely lost out on presence. These software tune in to TV channels, and capture screenshots and video in a compressed format. Some can pause a TV show.

The interface apart, the thin line that separates PVR software from Media Center software is the latter's additional functionality that integrates DVD, radio, picture and music playback capabilities using a remote control, while retaining the capabilities of PVR software.

The major parameters that we based our comparison of PVR software on were ease of use, features and performance. We took a detailed look at six software in all—ChrisTV, iuVCR, NeoTV, PowerVCR II 3.0, WinDVR, and WinVDR.

ChrisTV

ChrisTV is a unique contender in the category of PVR software—unique because the interface is so dull! But make no mistake—all the functionality is there: everything you need is a right-click away.

Ease Of Use

Installation is wizard-based, at the end of which you're prompted to configure the settings. The process also includes setting up a video capture device. This is an important step; make sure you select your TV-Tuner card, since your graphics card can also serve as an input source for PVR software.

The interface is compact and the colour combination dull, like we said. It looks like a failed attempt at aping the Mac OS user interface! The buttons on the panel make all the important functions accessible. Advanced settings become accessible with a right-click. Clicking the "gear" icon button opens the 'General Settings' menu. This menu is at the heart of ChrisTV's configuration.

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